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‘WHAT THE CHURCH NEEDS TO BE’

Women defy the Catholic hierarchy to become priests

Story by Jonathan Bullington | Photos by Eileen T. Meslar | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ST. LOUIS — The entire day had been building to this moment. First there was the procession, then the readings and songs and the sponsors who explained why they felt she was ready for what was to come.

She prostrated before the altar inside the old church, her chest heaving with emotion as the Litany of the Saints was said. She sat in a folding chair, tears trickling down her cheeks, while each person in the pews came forward to place their hands on her head in a quiet blessing.

And as the noon hour arrived and Anna Girresch — Annie to those who know her — held out her hands to be anointed with oil, it felt like all 70-plus people in attendance collectively held their breaths as the ritual neared its culmination.

It came seconds later, when a bishop raised Annie’s right hand toward the ceiling and, “with great joy,” introduced her as a newly ordained Catholic priest.

The congregation — Annie’s parents and sisters, nephews and friends and 12 other women whose ranks she joined that last Saturday in June — stood and cheered for a full minute.

No one seemed bothered that they had just been willing participants in a ceremony the Roman Catholic Church deems a grave sin, or that Annie had just incurred one of its most severe punishments: automatic and immediate excommunication.

“I’m just filled with the spirit right now and so blessed that she’s going to go forth and share God with all the people that she touches,” her father, Wil Girresch, said between thanking people who stopped to congratulate him.

Above: Annie Girresch, center, receives a kiss from her mentor, Elsie McGrath, on the day Girresch joined McGrath as an ordained Catholic priest. The ceremony was held at St. John’s United Church of Christ in St. Louis on June 27.

“This is what the church needs to be,” added his wife, Ellen Girresch. “Accepting. Supporting.”

Annie is the latest in a line of women, some 300 in all, scattered across the United States and in at least nine other countries, who in the last two decades have defied the Catholic Church to be ordained as deacons, priests and bishops.

These women — cradle Catholics and converts, former nuns, teachers, hospice chaplains, coun-

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ELECTION 2026

Dems face competing demands if they win

The party split on how hard to fight Trump if control of Congress flips

By Daniel C. Vock
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

WASHINGTON — Illinois Democrats may be savoring the possibility their party could retake the U.S. House, and possibly the Senate, after next month’s elections, but the state’s likely incoming and returning lawmakers are split on how aggressively to use that power against Republican President Donald Trump.

If Democrats win back power in the Nov. 3 midterms in a year when experts and polling predict a blue wave of Democratic victories in congressional races, they still will face competing demands on their time and attention.

They could tackle the economic issues that have dragged down Trump’s popularity in recent months, but they would need Republican support to get those measures to the president’s desk and signed into law.

Or they could reassert Congress’ power and try to thwart many of Trump’s unilateral actions, which would alienate Republicans and likely anger the president.

All of that will play out as the term-limited Trump approaches lame-duck status and Democrats lay the groundwork to retake the White House in 2028.

“Congress is designed to operate on two parallel paths: The oversight track and the legislative track. We need to do both,” said U.S. Rep. Brad Schneider, who represents Chicago’s north suburbs and chairs the New Democrat Coalition, a caucus of more than 100 moderate Democratic House members.

“Irrespective of who wins the majority, it’s imperative that we restore checks and balances to our government,” he told the Tribune. “Those checks and balances have been weakened before the Trump administration, and the Trump

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Raids came home ‘when it happened to Jose’

Voters wrestle with support of Trump immigration policies — until it ensnares someone they know

By Gregory Royal Pratt
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

PARIS, Ill. — In his dreams, Jose Fiscal Belli is still living an all-American life with his all-American family.

Each day, he comes home to his wife, a hazel-eyed, small-town preacher’s daughter. Together, they raise four children and run the Main Street Cafe, where they serve country fried chicken and eggs to a feisty bunch of regulars. He also co-owns a Mexican restaurant just across the state line in Clinton, Indiana.

Everyone knows Jose in Paris, Illinois, located about 165 miles south of Chicago. He coaches Little League. Police officers ask for his help as a volunteer Spanish translator. He is known to donate whole meals to the local soup kitchen. When 8-year old Crosby Allen needed a new bat but didn’t have the money, Jose gave him one.

He fits right into the mostly white town of roughly 8,000 people where a laundromat offers free laundry day for those who can’t afford it and a local group builds wheelchair ramps for disabled residents.

But Jose, 32, is not in Paris anymore. Instead of living the American Dream, he wakes up to a nightmare in ICE custody. He was picked up earlier this summer after Indiana State Police stopped him outside a government building in Indianapolis where he had parked in the wrong spot. The officers turned him over to federal immigration agents, and he is being detained at the Oldham County Jail in La Grange, Kentucky, where he faces deportation.

Now, a town that voted overwhelmingly for President Donald Trump is contending with Jose’s absence. The Prairie Press, a local

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Courtney Fiscal Belli gets a hug from her son, Legend Fiscal Belli, 4, at the restaurant she runs with her husband, Main Street Cafe, on Oct. 9 in downstate Paris. Fiscal Belli’s husband, Jose, was detained by federal agents in Indianapolis in July. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Bears look to bounce back from loss

The Bears haven’t let bad losses multiply under head coach Ben Johnson. That makes Sunday’s game against the Falcons significant. **Sports**

Trump’s Russia move irks Congress

Lawmakers from both parties blasted the president’s decision to waive sanctions on Russia days before they were to start. **Nation & World, Page B5**

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